

Session 7: Embodying Culturally Responsive Mentoring

Role-Play Scenarios

During our final live session, we will be acting out scenarios in pairs. Please select one of the following scenarios and think about how you would incorporate the skills you've learned in this course to respond to the mentee. You will have time to practice with your scene partner during the live session.

Scenario 1

Juana is a PhD student funded by your National Science Foundation grant in the U.S. She used to be engaged in her research, but over the last few months she has been falling behind in her work. You are annoyed with her absence from group meetings and lack of productivity, so you schedule a one-on-one conversation with her. When you ask why Juana is dropping the ball, she says she's having trouble prioritizing work when science agencies are being defunded and federal workers are experiencing reductions in force. She tries every week to make progress on her work, but it's hard to see the point when the future of the field and science as a whole is so uncertain.

Scenario 2

Jackson is a Black graduate student in your department who is having a negative experience with their research advisor. They were on the verge of quitting the program, so you offered to mentor them and help them improve their research skills. However, you have been inconsistent with them, often canceling meetings and forgetting to respond to their emails. Frustrated, Jackson comes to your office and asks you to consider whether you have the capacity to mentor them. They feel you might be overextending yourself, and it is affecting them negatively. Because they did not initially ask for your help, they are concerned about your involvement being a result of saviorism.

Scenario 3

Marissa is a postdoc who comes to you with some concerns she is hoping you can address. She has received complaints about Steven, a 4th year graduate student, making sexist remarks to younger female students. Marissa has noticed how much the women distance themselves from Steven, and even overheard him dismissing the research of one of the female professors. You want to help bring attention to this issue, but you are a pre-tenure professor and Steven's advisor is the chair of the department. Your tenure review is in a year, and you are afraid that speaking out would alienate your colleagues and put a target on your back.